takes minimum responsibility for the territory – and citizens – in which its mining operations happen to be located, operating instead through global supply chains and the highly articulated flows that now characterise the global economy.

Corporations use 'branding' instruments to 'green wash' their images with strong language about sustainability, or 'blue wash' them, wrapping themselves in the legitimising language of the Global Compact and the United Nations. What is gilded for the public as the need for a 'social licence to operate' is put into internal company practice more as 'security risk management'. Companies are driven fundamentally by their concern for 'damage control', seeing any person or policy or institution that gets in their way as a security risk and, consequently, an 'enemy' of the corporation.

André Almeida, a former director in Vale's Department of Intelligence and Corporate Security, recently handed over large numbers of documents to Brazil's State Prosecutor. They point to Vale's involvement in widespread spying and infiltration focused on people and organisations deemed by Vale to be its enemies. These include well-respected journalists, lawyers and human rights activists, as well as organisations such as Justice on the Rails and the International Network of People Affected by Vale (Marshall 2013). The expanded vision of corporate self-interest expounded by Stiglitz seems to be very far from Vale's corporate game plans.

The elite social forces in Brazil and other BRICS countries that are intent on making their countries competitive in the global economy are part of the new transnational class of winners produced by globalisation. They are members of the 50% of the transnational consumer class that resides in the Global South, many with aspirations to be part of the '1%'. Through their multinational corporations like Vale, they aspire to industrial modernity and world-class consumption.

The aspirations of the government and business leaders in the BRICS to attain global status, measured by triumphs like hosting the Olympics or the World Cup, may genuinely include a component of recuperation of pride, dignity and respect after centuries of colonial and imperial humiliation. The vision pursued, however, offers no alternative to the current world order of production and consumption. The vision is not inclusive of the poor within their own nations and takes little cognisance of the impact of the growth model they aspire to on the long-term wellbeing of the planet. The strongly felt aspirations of the BRICS to be players in the current global system and 'world-class' consumers only serve to exacerbate existing rich–poor disparities and to inflict further damages on the environment, making them major perpetrators of ongoing global instability and injustice.